

Session 9: Out of Egypt

Key Takeaways

- Matthew casts the story of Jesus' birth as a retelling of the birth of Moses and the exodus.
- Just as Moses was adopted into the house of Pharaoh, so Jesus was adopted into the house of David.
- God's pattern of choosing Abraham, Israel, and David challenges our cultural practices of privileging only ourselves and those like us. God chooses one to bring blessing to the many.

Matthew 2:13-23

A 13 And after they departed,
look, **a messenger of the Lord** **shone-in-appearance** to Ioseph **in a dream**, saying,
"Getting up, take **the child** and his mother,
and flee **to Egypt** and be there until whenever I speak to you!
For **Herodes** is about **to seek** **the child**, to destroy him."

B 14 And **getting up, he took** **the child** and his mother by night,
and **he departed** **to Egypt**,

C 15 and he was there until **the death-end of** **Herodes**,
in order to **fill-full** what was spoken by the Lord through the prophet, saying,
"**From Egypt** I called **my son**."

16 Then (τοτε) **Herodes**, seeing that he had been deceptively-tricked by the **magi**,
he was enraged, very much,
and having sent, he did away with all **the children**,
who were in Bethle'em and in all its districts,
from two years old and below,
according to the time which he learned precisely from the **magi**.

17 **Then** (τοτε) **was** **filled-full** what was spoken through Ieremias the prophet, saying,

18 "A voice was heard in Rama,

crying and great grieving;
Rakhel crying for **her children**,
and she does not want to be comforted,
because they are no more.”

19 And after **Herodes came to his death-end**,
look **a messenger of the Lord shone-in-appearance** to Ioseph **in Egypt in a dream**, saying,
A' 20 “**Getting up, take the child and his mother,**
and go to the land of **Israel**,
for those **who seek** the life of **the child** have **died**.”

B' 21 And **getting up, he took the child and his mother,**
and he went to the land of **Israel**,

C' 22 and having heard that **Arkheleos ruled as king** of Ioudaia,
in the place of **his father Herodes**,
he was afraid and he left there,
and having been warned **in a dream**,
he departed into the region of Galilaia,
23 and having come, he lived in a city called “Nazaret,”
in order to fill-full what was spoken through the prophets,
that he would be called a Nazoraios.”

Matthew 2:13-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

This final panel of Matthew 1:18-2:23 has a very clear three-part symmetrical design.

- A — Angel appears, directing Ioseph to take Mary and child to Egypt, they do so
 - B — Herod's response (τοτε) + Scripture fulfillment (τοτε)
- A' — Angel appears, directing Joseph to take Mary and child to Israel, they do so

Notice the flight to Egypt and the return to Israel are coordinated so that, in a great reversal, Egypt becomes the place of refuge while Israel is the land of death and danger.

This design also coordinates the father-son pair of Herod the Great and Herod-Archelaos.

An Inverted Exodus and a New Pharaoh

This entire sequence is designed as an inverted Exodus story. The classic characters and scenes have all been changed so that the characters of Matthew's story have surprising correspondences with the Exodus story.

- Jesus and Joseph // Moses
- Herod and Herod-Archelaos // Pharaoh
- Israel // Egypt
- Galilee // Midian

Matthew 2:13-14

¹³ “Getting up, take the child and his mother, and **flee to Egypt** and be there until whenever I speak to you!

For **Herodes is about to seek the child, to destroy him.”**

¹⁴ And getting up, he took the child and his mother by night, and **he departed to Egypt** .

Matthew 2:19-20

¹⁹ And after Herodes came to his death-end, look a messenger of the Lord shone-in-appearance to Ioseph in Egypt in a dream, saying,

²⁰ “Getting up, take the child and his mother, **and go to the land of Israel, for those who seek the life of the child have died. “**

Matthew 2:21-23

²¹ And getting up, he took the child and his mother,

and he went to the land of Israel,

²² and having heard that Archelaos ruled as king of Ioudaia,

in the place of his father Herodes,

he was afraid and he left there,

and having been warned in a dream,

he departed into the region of Galilaia,

²³ **and having come, he dwelt in a city called**

“Nazeret”

Exodus 2:14b-15

^{14b} And **Moshe was afraid,** and said, “Surely, the matter has become known!”

¹⁵ And **Pharaoh** heard of this matter, and **he sought to murder Moshe,** and **Moshe fled** from before the face of Pharaoh, **and he dwelt in the land of Midyan,** and he dwelt by a well.

Exodus 4:19-20

¹⁹ And Yahweh said to Moshe in Midyan,

“Go, return to Egypt, because the men seeking your life have died.”

²⁰ And Moshe took his wife and his sons, and he had them ride on a donkey, and he returned to the land of Egypt,

Inverted Exodus and New Pharaoh. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

This portrait of Herod as a new Pharaoh is also programmatic for Matthew’s account as a whole, because Herod represents the Jerusalem regime set on “destroying” (ἀπολλύμι) the Messiah. Matthew will later portray Jesus’ opponents with similar language, linking them all back to Herod and thus to Pharaoh.

Matthew 2:13 NASB

“Get up! Take the child and his mother and flee to Egypt, and remain there until I tell you; for Herod is going to search for the child to **destroy** (απολλυμι) him.”

Matthew 12:14 NASB

But the Pharisees went out and conspired against him, as to how they might **destroy** (απολλυμι) him.

Matthew 27:20 NASB*

But the chief priests and the elders persuaded the crowds to ask for Barabbas and to **destroy** (απολλυμι) Jesus.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Out of Egypt I Called My Son”

In [Matthew 2:15](#), we find the third quotation from the Scriptures, a line from [Hosea 11:1](#) where the prophet recalls Israel’s exodus from Egypt in the past. In context, Hosea (in the 8th century B.C.E.) laments Israel’s current state of idolatry and covenant violation, and he warns that they will return to captivity. This is tragic because Israel as a nation is Yahweh’s son who was liberated from Egypt and is now headed toward captivity and slavery again. But this “return” to slavery won’t be to Egypt but to Assyria.

Hosea 11:1-5 LEB

¹ When Israel was a child, I loved him,
and **out of Egypt I called my son.**
² When I called them, they went from my face.
They sacrificed to the Baals, and they sacrificed to idols.
³ And I myself taught Ephraim to walk;
I took them in my arms,
but they did not know that I healed them.
⁴ I drew them with human ties,
with the bands of love.
I was to them like one who lifted up a yoke on their jaws,
though I bent down to them and let them eat.
⁵ **He will return to the land of Egypt,**
and Assyria will be his king,
because they refused to return.

Matthew most likely adopts this line from Hosea not only because of the recall of the exodus from Egypt, but also because of the designation of Israel as God’s son. Also, Hosea shows that the Egyptian slavery of the past has become a symbol of the coming Assyrian enslavement.

This text from Hosea is also hyperlinked to an important text in the Exodus story itself, where Moses’ own deliverance from the Egyptian Pharaoh through the waters ([Exod. 1-4](#)) is designed as a narrative foreshadowing of all Israel’s deliverance through the waters ([Exod. 5-15](#)).

Exodus 4:22-23 LEB

²² And you must say to Pharaoh, “Thus says Yahweh, ‘**Israel is my son, my firstborn.**’

²³ And I said to you, ‘Release my son and let him serve me,’ but you refused to release him. Look, I am about to kill your son, your firstborn.”

Another relevant set of hyperlinks for Matthew’s quotation of [Hosea 11:1](#) consists of passages that anticipate a future king from the lineage of David, who will undergo an “exodus” that is set on analogy to Israel’s exodus from Egypt.

Numbers 24:5-8 LEB

⁵ How good are your tents, O Jacob,
your dwellings, O Israel!

⁶ They are spread out like valleys,
like gardens on a river,
like aloes planted by Yahweh,
like cedars at the waters.

⁷ He will pour water from his buckets,
and his offspring will be like many waters;
his king will be higher than Agag,
and **his kingdom** will be exalted.

⁸ God, **who brings him out from Egypt**,
is like the strength of a wild ox for him.

Psalms 2:7-8 LEB

⁷ I will tell the decree; Yahweh said to me:

“You are my son;
today I have birthed you.

⁸ Ask from me and I will make the nations your heritage,
and your possession the ends of the earth.

It’s useful to reconstruct the network of allusions to help us see how Matthew’s mind worked and how he saw various parts of the Hebrew Bible as interconnected.

[Matthew 2:15](#) quotes [Hosea 11:1](#), which is hyperlinked to [Exodus 4:26](#), which is portrayed by [Numbers 24:5-6](#) as a narrative analogy between Moses’ exodus ([Exod. 1-4](#)), Israel’s exodus ([Exod. 5-15](#)), and the deliverance of the future divine son of David ([Ps. 2, 18](#)).

“Rachel Weeping for Her Children”

Matthew’s fourth Old Testament quotation in the introduction comes from [Jeremiah 31:15](#), where the prophet portrays the matriarch of Israel grieving for the downfall and destruction of her children. Matthew connects this quotation with the death of the children of Bethlehem who were ruthlessly murdered by King Herod.

As in the previous Old Testament quote, Matthew quotes this text because it has hyperlinked associations with many other stories in the Hebrew Bible that provide meaningful narrative analogies with the story of

Jesus and Herod.

In context, Jeremiah portrays Rachel's weeping as a sign of Israel's devastation that will soon come to an end.

Jeremiah 31:15-16 LEB

¹⁵ Thus says Yahweh,

**"A voice is heard in Ramah,
lamentation, the weeping of bitterness.
Rachel is weeping for her children;
she refuses to be comforted because of her children,
for they are no more."**

¹⁶ Thus says Yahweh:

"Restrain your voice from weeping,
and your eyes from tears,
for there is a reward for your work," declares Yahweh,
"and they will return from the land of the enemy."

In context, Jeremiah is appealing to the story of Rachel weeping for her lost sons and refusing to be comforted. This recalls two moments in Genesis that provide the language for Jeremiah 31:15-16.

Genesis 30:22-24 NASB

²² Then **God remembered Rachel**, and God gave heed to her and opened her womb. ²³ **So she conceived and bore a son** and said, "God has taken away my reproach." ²⁴ **She named him Joseph**, saying, "May the LORD give me another son."

Genesis 35:16-19 NASB

¹⁶ Then they journeyed from Bethel; and when there was still some distance to go to Ephrath, **Rachel began to give birth and she suffered severe labor.** ¹⁷ **When she was in severe labor** the midwife said to her, "Do not fear, for now you have another son." ¹⁸ It came about as her soul was departing (for she died), that **she named him Ben-oni; but his father called him Benjamin.** ¹⁹ So **Rachel died and was buried** on the way to Ephrath (that is, **Bethlehem**).

Genesis 37:33-35 NASB

³³ Then he examined it and said, "It is my son's tunic. A wild beast has devoured him; Joseph has surely been torn to pieces!" ³⁴ So Jacob tore his clothes, and put sackcloth on his loins and mourned for his son many days. ³⁵ Then all his sons and all his daughters arose to comfort him, but **he refused to be comforted.** And he said, "Surely I will go down to Sheol in mourning for my son." So **his father wept for him.**

Genesis 42:13 Instructor's Translation

But they said, "Your servants are twelve brothers in all, the sons of one man in the land of Canaan; and behold, the youngest is with our father today, **and one is no more.**"

Genesis 42:31-32 NASB

³¹ “But we said to him, ‘We are honest men; we are not spies. ³² We are twelve brothers, sons of our father; **one is no more**, and the youngest is with our father today in the land of Canaan.’”

Genesis 44:20 NASB

“We said to my lord, ‘We have an old father and a little child of his old age. Now **his brother is no more, so he alone is left of his mother, and his father loves him.**’”

In this network of texts, we have a number of narrative analogies working together.

- Rachel, the mother of Joseph, was Jacob’s “beloved” wife who died an untimely death.
- As she gave birth to Benjamin, she grieved and died, and she was buried near Bethlehem.
- When Joseph was betrayed by his brothers and presumed dead, Jacob refused to be comforted and wept.
- Three times Joseph is said to be “no more.”
- The final time this phrase appears, we are told that Benjamin is the only son left from Rachel, and he is especially beloved.

This network of texts in Genesis explores just how tragic Israel’s fate has become among the nations. Brother betraying brother, tragic deaths and murders, all the sad result of humanity choosing to define good and bad by their own wisdom. And it leads Jacob’s family into exile ... in Egypt!

Jeremiah 31 brings together these themes and sees Rachel (buried near Bethlehem, birthplace of David and Jesus) weeping like Jacob over her lost children. In Jeremiah’s context, this applies to the lost generations of the Babylonian exile and destruction of Jerusalem. But the fact that Jeremiah adopts the image of Rachel and portrays her in the mourning role of Jacob from the Joseph story shows that the prophet wants us to see how these stories of the past prefigure the large-scale tragedies of Israel’s story in the future. The tragedy of Babylonian exile was yet another cycle of betrayal and death in Israel’s story, so that the matriarch now weeps from the grave over her children.

Matthew adopts the lines from Jeremiah 31:15 with full awareness of its hyperlinked nature, as he too is exploring an act of betrayal (Israel’s king murdering his people’s children) that led to another exile in Egypt (the Messiah’s). The analogy between these Old Testament stories (Rachel, Jacob, Joseph, and Jeremiah) and the story of Herod and Jesus runs deep. These stories illuminate each other and point forward to a hopeful resolution.

“He Will Be Called a Nazoraioi”

After returning from Egypt, Joseph leads his new family to Nazareth in Galilee. Archaeologists estimate that the town had a population of 500.

In this geographical move, Matthew sees another connection to the story of the Scriptures. This is the only quotation that he attributes to “the prophets” as a group. This makes sense, because there is nowhere in the Hebrew or Greek Bible that contains the line: “He will be called a Nazoraioi.” Also, Matthew has adapted the quotation formula by adding the conjunction “that” (ὅτι) before the phrase, showing that “he would be called a Nazoraioi” is not a quotation proper, but a reference to an idea or theme found in the Prophets.

It is most likely that Matthew has provided a riddle for the reader that leads to multiple hyperlinks in the Hebrew Bible, but all roads lead back to [Isaiah 4:2-3](#) and [11:1-2](#).

Isaiah 4:2-3 Instructor's Translation

² In that day,
the **sprout of YHWH** will be
for beauty and for honor,
and the fruit of the land will be
for pride and for beauty
for the escaped-remnant of Yisrael.

³ And the one remaining in Zion,
and the one left-over in Yerushalayim,
he will be called a holy one,
everyone who is written for life in Yerushalayim.

Isaiah 11:1 NASB

Then **a shoot** will spring from the stem of Jesse,
and **a branch** (Heb. *netser* / נצר) from his roots will bear fruit.

These two texts are deeply connected in the design of [Isaiah 1-12](#) because both portray the growth of a messianic plant connected with a faithful remnant in Jerusalem that will become the seed of a renewed Israel who will spread the Eden blessing to the nations.

1. Meaning #1: “branch/shoot” rhymes in Hebrew with the name of the town “Nazeret.”
 - The word shoot in [Isaiah 11:1](#) is *netser* in Hebrew (likely pronounced *natsr* in the 1st century). This provides an almost exact wordplay: The *netser* / נצר is from *natseret* / נצרת!
2. Meaning #2: “he will be called a holy one” = “he will be called a Nazirite!”
 - In the Old Greek Septuagint, we find a curious feature: When the figure of the “Nazirite” (Heb. *nazir* / נזיר = “a set-apart one”) appears, the translators sometimes simply transliterate it with the word “Naziraion” (Grk. *ναζιραιος*, see [Judg. 13:7](#), [16:17](#)), but other times they interpret the word instead and so render the word as “the holy one of God” (*αγιος θεου*, see Codex A and B for [Judg. 13:7](#) and [16:17](#)).
 - This is significant because Jesus himself is called “the holy one of God” multiple times in the New Testament ([Mark 1:24](#), [Luke 4:34](#), [John 6:69](#)). In other words, Jesus was viewed as a type of Nazirite by the earliest Christians.
 - While Jesus was no ascetic (he regularly drank wine), he did at his final Passover vow to never drink again until the Kingdom of God has arrived ([Matt. 26:29](#)), and he refused wine-vinegar during his crucifixion ([Matt. 27:48](#)).

Reflection Question

What parallels does Matthew draw between Jesus’ story and Moses or the exodus?